

Q Should I always offer my baby both breasts at every feeding?

There are no hard and fast rules—it's best to be guided by your baby and watch out for signs that he is full. You may find that when your milk comes in, sometime during the first week, your breasts are very full and your baby may be satisfied feeding from one side only. This is fine and you just need to remember to start the next feeding session on the other side so that your

milk supply is even, and so that one nipple doesn't become sore from overuse. If you struggle to remember which side you last fed from, try switching a bracelet or hair band from one wrist to the other, or just make a note of which side you fed from.

You may find that your baby continues to be happy feeding from just one side. Or, as your milk supply settles down, your baby may want to feed from both sides in one feeding session. If he seems unsettled when you take him off the breast, try offering the second side.

It's important that your baby stays on one breast long enough to get both the watery hydrating foremilk, and the creamier hindmilk, so don't move him to the other breast too soon.

When your baby has growth spurts, which are frequent in the first weeks and months, you may find that he is dissatisfied for a day or so after just one side and needs to nurse from the second breast. If he is very hungry, you may even need to return to the first breast and nurse until he is satisfied. Your breasts will increase their supply in line with your baby's needs.

Q How do I burp my baby and is it always necessary?

It is good practice to burp your baby after a feeding because this will release any trapped air that he has swallowed along with his milk that could make him fussy, uncomfortable, and hard to settle down.

If your baby appears to be fussy midway through a feeding, perhaps squirming and coming away from the breast unsettled, he may need to be burped to release trapped air before he can continue. Bottle-fed babies (see pp.278–81) tend to take in more air.

As your baby grows, you will become accustomed to his needs, and you may find that you need to burp him routinely, or that sometimes he settles down without being burped.

Your baby may bring up, or spit up, a little of his milk when he burps—this is quite normal. Having a burp cloth ready to catch any milk spit-up can save your clothes.

If your baby suffers quite a bit with gas, try keeping him upright for around 20 minutes after a feeding since this can help to bring up trapped gas, easing his discomfort. If he's having trouble burping, try switching positions or applying a little more pressure.

BURPING POSITIONS

There are a few positions for burping. As with feeding positions, you and your baby will probably settle on the burping technique you both find most comfortable and effective.



Hold baby over your shoulder A newborn's body is suited to being held upright with his head supported over your shoulder, while you gently rub or pat his back. Place a burp cloth over your shoulder to protect your clothing in case your baby spits up some milk.



Lay baby face down Hold your baby face down across your arm or your lap, with his head a little higher than his body. Make sure his head is properly supported, then gently rub or pat his back to help release the trapped air in his tummy.



Sit baby upright, chin supported When your baby's neck muscles are a little stronger, try sitting him on your lap, your palm supporting his chest and your thumb and forefinger spread out to support his chin. Rub or pat his back.